


SWIPE →

— FROM SCAPEGOAT TO TARGET

# I was trained for this job *before I ever applied.*

How a scapegoat childhood taught me to give bullies too many chances.

# Youngest of nine. The scapegoat.

In a narcissistic family, people get roles. The **scapegoat** carries the blame, so the family never has to change.

I wrote in my memoir that I was “the least believed. The most conditioned to be seen as an unreliable narrator of my own experiences.”

## Then I got a job.

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Source: “Scapegoat” here is a family-systems idea from popular psychology, not a diagnosis.

SAME PLAY, NEW STAGE

# Family roles, workplace roles

| AT HOME | | AT WORK |
| --- | --- | --- |
| The scapegoat | → | The “problem employee” |
| Siblings doing a parent's dirty work | → | Coworkers repeating the narrative |
| “Don't air the family business” | → | “Keep it within the team” |
| Being called a liar | → | “That never happened” |
| The golden child | → | The agreeable one who gets promoted |

# My hypervigilance looked like patience.

I was trained to anticipate mistakes, mine and everyone else's. So I kept giving chances. I kept waiting for people to do the right thing.

Because admitting they wouldn't meant admitting I was on my own again.

RESEARCH NOTE

# Lots of people would rather justify a mistake than admit it.

Social psychologists Carol Tavris and Elliot Aronson describe **self-justification**: once someone has hurt you, admitting it threatens how they see themselves, so they rewrite the story instead.

## More chances won't change someone who needs you to be the problem.

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Source: Tavris & Aronson, *Mistakes Were Made (But Not by Me)*, 2007

# A different way to give chances

1. Give one chance, and name it out loud.
2. Write down what happened the same day.
3. Tell one safe person, outside of work.
4. Pay attention to what people do more than to their apologies.
5. Let “I see the pattern” be enough. You don't need them to agree.




COMING NEXT ON SUBSTACK

# Part 2: The Least Believed

What a childhood as the scapegoat taught me, and what it cost me at work.

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**Link in bio. If you were the scapegoat too, comment “same.”**